

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper in Hong Kong:

Music unplugged

Following the death of a 72-year-old man on Sunday during a fight between Leisure and Culture Services Department (LCSD) officials and performers, the Tuen Mun District Council held a meeting to look for more venues for the elderly to enjoy outdoor music performances.

Large crowds of retired people gather at Tuen Mun Park for free musical performances, especially on Saturdays and Sundays. The crowds enjoy singing and dancing to the music. Some performers use electronic music and amplifiers in the park, which is against regulations.

The LCSD received 400 noise complaints from last November to February. The number of complaints dropped to five from February to May after the department strictly enforced the ban on electronic music and amplifiers. However, enforcing the ban has caused trouble between performers and officials. Singing groups complained that singing without amplification was similar to “cooking without salt”.

Tuen Mun district councillor Chan Wan-sang said the department planned to install a HK\$50 million soundproof system in the park's theatre, and allow the use of amplifiers in one area, with noise not exceeding 70 decibels.

Mr Chan urged the department to open up more venues for the elderly people to perform music, saying one area will not be enough. Chan said unused squash courts and community centres should be provided for the elderly free-of-charge to ease the problem.

You are doing a social studies project on “Keeping the Elderly Active”. You are meeting to discuss this issue. You may want to talk about:

- why the elderly enjoy singing in parks
- problems with having outdoor music performances
- ways to overcome these problems
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do older people in your family enjoy singing?
2. What do elderly people enjoy doing in their free time?
3. What is the difference between the songs the elderly enjoy and those the young enjoy?
4. Have you ever seen groups of elderly people singing in the park?
5. Are there activities that are not suitable for the elderly?
6. Why is it important for the elderly to keep busy?
7. Why do some old people prefer to stay at home?
8. Should retirement be something to look forward to or to worry about?